Final Project Application

Brief FPA33501: Design Concept Development

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Submitted in partial fulfillment of the requirements of

BACHELORS OF DESIGN SPECIALISING IN IDEATION

In the subject

Final Project Application

At

INSCAPE EDUCATION GROUP

Pretoria Campus

Lecturer

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Introduction

Brief Overview

The brief requires us to work through five stages: Identify, Research, Construct, Evaluate and Refine. During the Identify stage, we must identify a design challenge or problem within one of the chosen categories, the categories being: Design that Shapes Identity, Design that Shapes Systems or Design that Shapes Innovation, then use a range of sources and later in the research phase reflect on the insights. The Research stage requires us to conduct in-depth, rigorous research on the previously selected design problem, building a foundation of understanding and context. The Construct stage is the time to develop the solution to the design problem using relevant methods. The Evaluate phase includes all the prototyping and testing, case studies, questionnaires and surveys, Peer Feedback, etc., with a focus on how the user would interact with the proposed design solution. The refine stage, as it is called, involves refining the solution using feedback and proposing a timeline with milestones, technical requirements, and execution plans.

The theme selected in this brief is Design that Shapes Systems, with the chosen design problem being helping graduates entering the freelance market. This one is personally relevant to me. I intend to enter the freelance market but have little to no idea what the requirements are, what I need to provide for the target market, or what to expect when moving into freelance work.

The aim is to explore and define the selected problem, conduct primary research to gain insight, and develop a contextually relevant and iterative design solution. Graduates who want to move into the freelance market may have the skills to apply but lack a clear practical business knowledge to secure their first opportunity.

Identify

The freelance work market in South Africa is steadily growing, with the youth taking the charge, and 47% of employees in South Africa having a side job or remote work due to the impact of Covid-19 (Media Update, 2025). The freelance industry is proving to be a stable financial choice, with income generated through freelance platform markets reaching $108 million as of 2024 and expected to increase to $306.2 million by 2030 (Media Update, 2025).

The flexibility of freelance work has become more appealing to young South Africans. The autonomy and access to diverse fields that it offers, especially in South Africa, where the youth unemployment rate is over 46% (Media Update, 2025) and has been quite high for some time now.

This project will aim to target final-year students or recent creative degree graduates in South Africa. This narrowing of the target audience will help target the specific needs of the target users. Freelancing in the current market is often assumed to be an alternative to a deliberate career choice (Media Update, 2025). In the same way, freelance work is commonly assumed to be very temporary and to supplement a person's income (Media Update, 2025). According to the 2026 State of the South African Freelance Economy (2026), there is an assumption that the creative sectors face an oversupply of freelancers, while IT and development-type freelancers are in balance.

Research

The overall aim of this project is to develop a solution to help graduates position themselves in the freelance market by enhancing their understanding of the system and business model that surrounds it, especially in the design sector, which is currently oversaturated. To start research, some research questions need to be defined to streamline the process.

- ➔ How can graduates be better prepared for the transition into the freelance market?
- ➔ What does higher education do to prepare graduates for employment, but not for freelancing?
- ➔ Why would graduates not want to enter the freelance market and settle for regular employment instead?
- ➔ What business skills are required for a graduate to be able to sustain their freelance work?

According to Indeed (2026), just having technical or professional skills is not enough for most people to succeed as freelancers. Other skills they note include communication, self-marketing, and negotiation. Freelancing requires graduates to move beyond being just professionally skilled to independent self-management and client communication.

The hiring costs of permanent employees for companies in South Africa are becoming less practical, especially when managing operational costs (The Hire Resolve Team, 2026). New digital media for companies to use are ever evolving, leading to companies struggling to teach their permanent employees the new tech and methods (The Hire Resolve Team, 2026). Freelance workers in this context are generally cheaper to hire for companies that struggle with management and the costs of permanent employees; consequently, they also tend to understand and use the latest technology and digital media. This makes freelance work more desirable for companies to hire, making the market for getting hired and the actual possibility of making a living through freelance work not just possible but stable.

➔ **What skills do graduates think they lack when entering the freelance market?**

The National Association of Colleges and Employers (NACE) have found that graduates rate their own skills very differently from how employers would rate them. Graduates tend to rate their own communication and leadership skills higher than what an employer with experience would (NACE, 2025).

Graduates cannot rely on the support structures provided by an organisation they want to join and that there are improvements graduates can make in their own communication and project management. The fact is that graduates are already showing signs that they do not meet expectations makes it a major problem in freelance environments.

➔ **Why would graduates not want to enter the freelance market and settle for regular employment instead?**

Unlike regular employees, freelancers cannot rely on company benefits, such as a monthly income and medical coverage. This can be seen by graduates as a financially risky journey as compared to a stable job, which has all the benefits (LinkedIn, 2026). According to the research (Ghai, 2024), Graduates face issues with clients because clients and businesses want experienced freelancers, while graduates need clients to gain experience to meet the requirements for working freelance, creating a systemic issue (Ghai, 2024). This makes it harder for new and upcoming freelancers to secure a position where they could start their career.

This creates an expectation for graduates to have experience before they can start freelancing. The concept of freelancing is not just about being able to do the work; it also requires that they be able to find clients and market themselves at a fair price that is in line with the current market demand (John, 2026). All these findings support the idea to a graduate that the freelance market is unforgiving and requires a lot of self-work outside of the skills they learned in university. It highlights areas that need work, such as the prep and knowledge phases, where graduates simply lack sufficient industry knowledge to move forward sustainably.

Interview

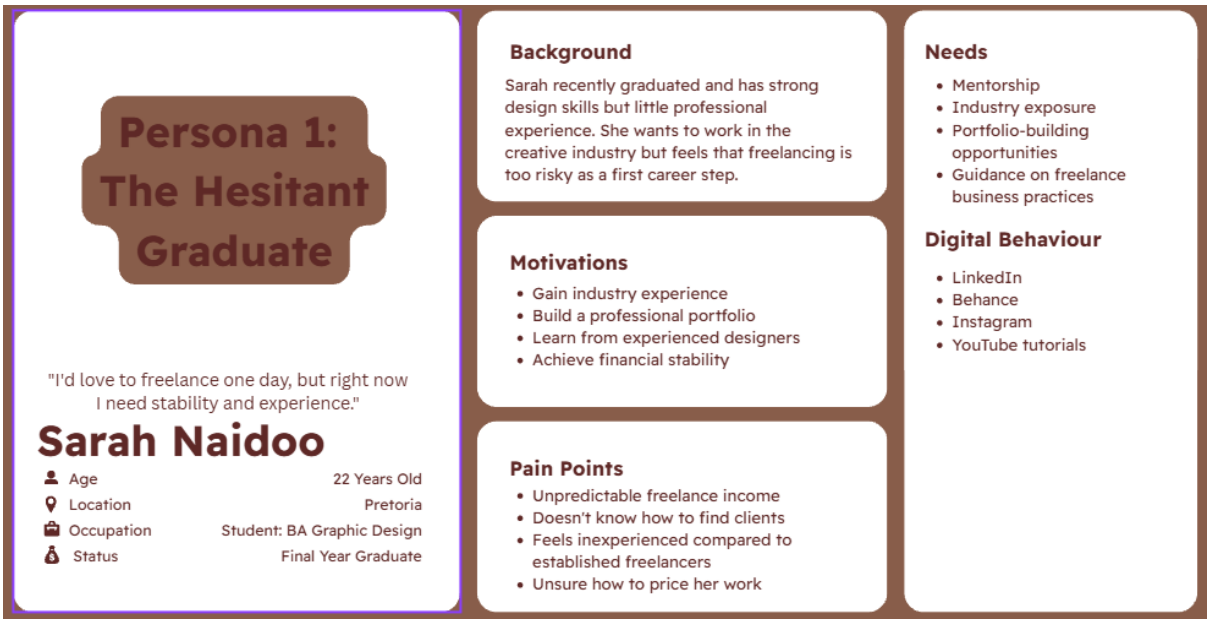
On the 28 of August in 2026, I conducted a consensual interview with a woman who works with freelancers as a hirer. These are the questions asked and what information I gathered from it:

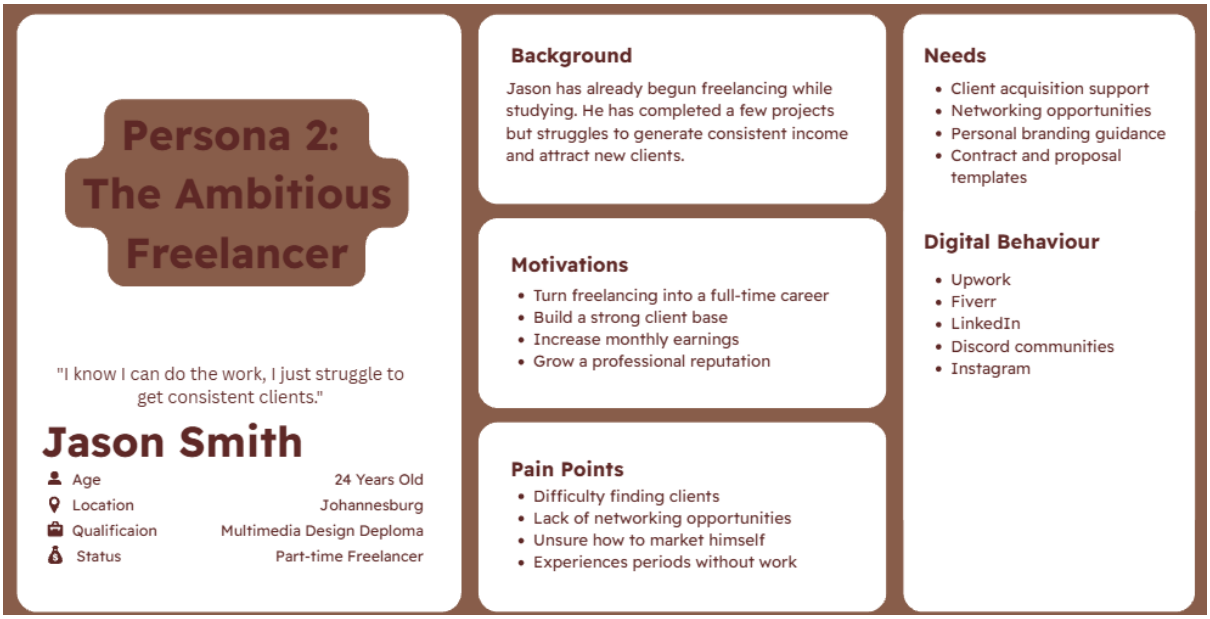
1. **Tell me about your experience working with freelancers?**
    a. Very time-consuming and flaky. It takes someone with self-business sense. There are also higher expectations, especially with clients, and the ability to share the same idea.
2. **What made you choose freelancers in the first place?**
    a. Startups and the culture surrounding startups. Freelancers have low expectations of themselves. Creates an opportunity for freelancers to make more money through experience. Freelancers tend to overcommit to their work
3. **What do you look for when deciding whether to hire a freelancer?**

    a. Portfolio is very important. Tech savviness, considering that design freelancers are behind in the tech and, importantly, in emotional intelligence.
4. **What problems or frustrations have you experienced?**
    a. Lack of previous experience doing freelance work and the inability to work with specific customers.
5. **What factors influence whether you choose to work with a freelancer or another type of professional or service?**
    a. Personal choice.
6. **What do you think new or inexperienced freelancers often misunderstand about working with clients?**
    a. Basic work skills, setup when starting with clients. Adaptation and communication skills.
7. **What could universities do to better prepare graduates for working with clients**
    a. Freelance programs and build relationships with startups, internships.
8. **If you could improve one thing about the experience of working with new freelancers, what would it be?**
    a. Communication! Honesty, Bravery and Confidence

From the secondary research and the interview conducted, it is safe to assume that many graduates feel uncertain and reluctant to enter the freelance market because of the required level of business skills, and that freelancing can be financially unsustainable if not managed well. The threat of graduates finding their own clients and the need for mentoring further discourage them from pursuing freelance work. From the interview, we can identify areas of the freelance process that can serve as a starting point for solution development.

Personas







The persona Sarah represents a graduate who is currently avoiding freelancing as an option. Jason is a graduate actively trying to use freelancing as an income stream, but is struggling. Michelle represents the hiring side of freelancing, validating the skill gaps identified in the previous research.

From these personas we can see that both Sarah and Jason are sufficiently skilled to perform the work, but both lack something that causes the business side to struggle. Sarah currently lacks confidence and knowledge of the freelance process, meanwhile Jason can complete projects but is struggling to secure consistent clients. This highlights that client acquisition is a barrier for graduates transitioning to freelance work and that communication and professionalism influence success in the freelancing market.

Construct

The research gathered in the research section of this brief shows that there are a few opportunities have emerged. There is wiggle room to support graduates in developing freelance business skills, given evidence that they feel unprepared. There is also an opportunity for a program that connects graduates with industry mentors for guided learning and networking.

How might we

How might we help graduates with the confidence and business knowledge so they can successfully enter the freelance market and secure a financially sustainable and rewarding freelance lifestyle?

Ideation and Concept Development

Concept 1:

> A mentorship platform for only connecting graduates with experienced and verified full-time freelancers. This helps graduates with their lack of industry experience and can receive guidance directly from the source. More active participation from universities is needed, including contacting willing freelancers to provide mentoring.

Concept 2:

> A second idea is a freelance skills academy of sorts focused on preparing graduates for freelancing. This can help graduates develop the skills required for freelancing. This also comes with the benefit of being scalable and can be built for universities or hosted as an independent service. One possible problem is that it will not provide graduates with adequate networking opportunities to help them find their first clients.

Concept 3:

> A graduate freelance hub. This is an ecosystem that combines mentoring, learning, and networking into a single space to solve multiple of the pain points discussed and offering a more holistic solution that connects the many parts that make up freelancing. This, however, makes it much more complicated to do correctly, with a much higher risk than concepts 1 or 2.

The concept chosen for this brief will be the third concept (The Graduate Freelance Hub) because it addresses the most significant challenges that were previously identified. Namely it refers to their confidence, freelancing knowledge, and networking and potential client acquisition.

Solution Overview

The graduate freelance hub is a digital service (website) that will help graduates transition into freelance work, if they choose to. The focus of this solution is to provide graduates with mentorship and networking opportunities through beginner-friendly, client-based projects.

Some of the core features for this hub would include teaching graduates about pricing guidelines and how to approach and speak with clients to secure work. The graduates would also be able to get one-on-one guidance from mentors through the website who would be able to conduct portfolio reviews. Lastly, it would provide access to entry-level freelance projects and internship opportunities through practice briefs they could obtain.

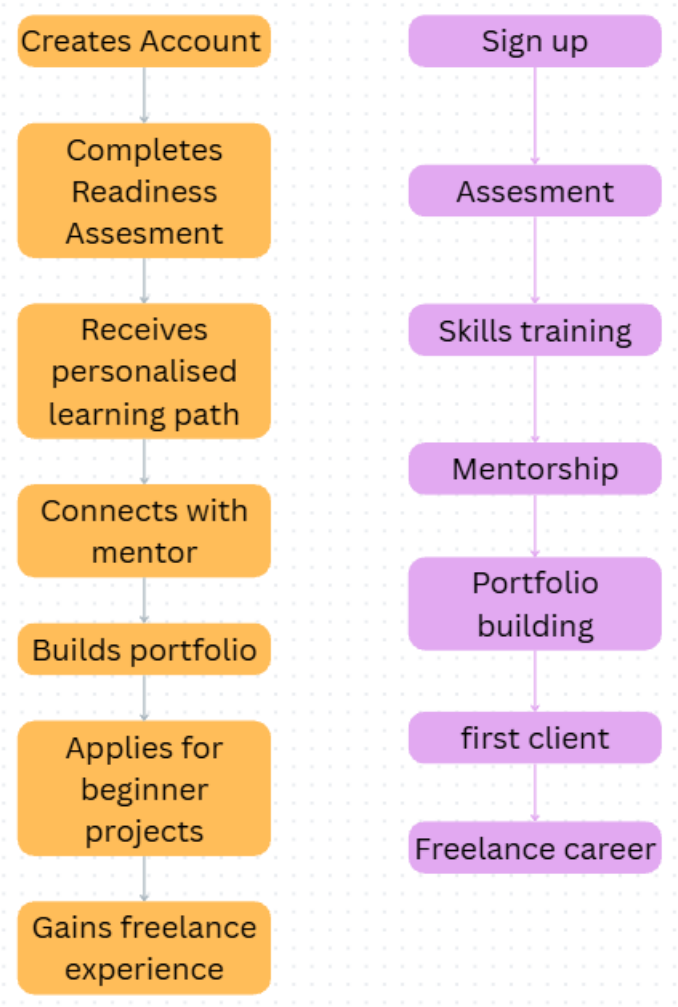


Figure 1 Simple User Journey for the Freelance Hub

Wireframes

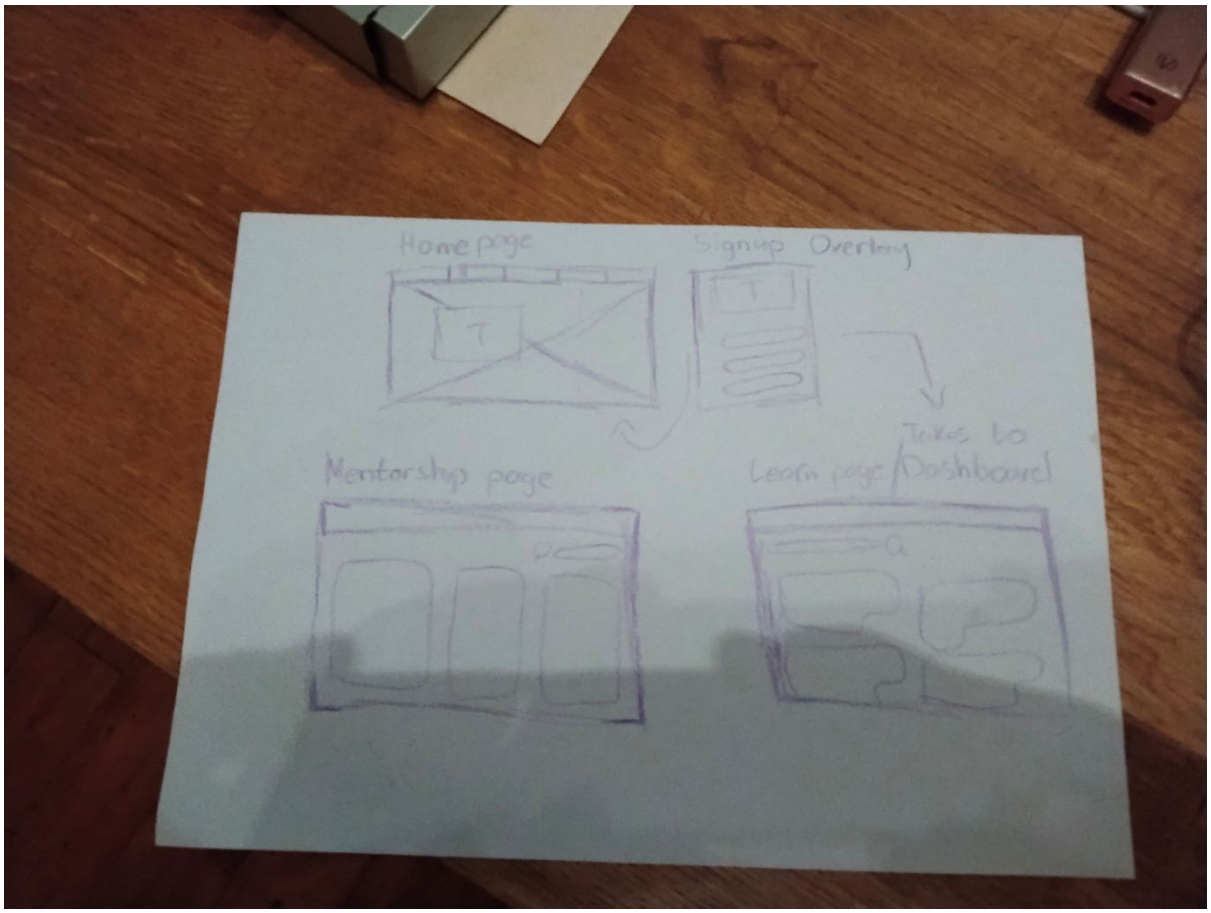


Figure 2 Low-Fidelity Wireframe of the Website

Evaluate

In this stage of the brief, the aim is to test the website design with people to recieve feedback on the user flow and other metrics to enhance the project further to reach a better solution

Prototype

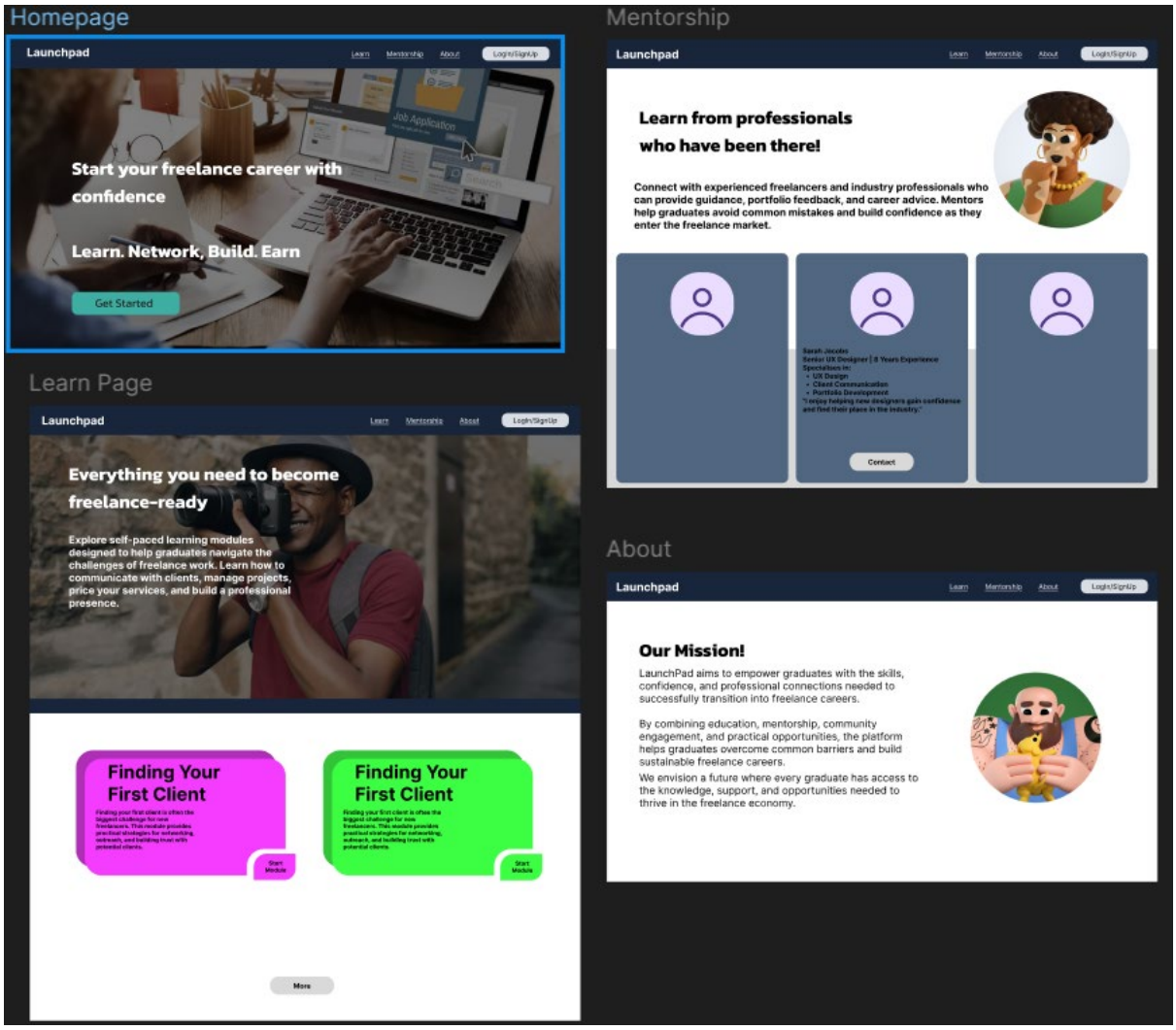


Figure 3 Prototype of Launchpad

Evaluation Method

I showed the high-fidelity prototype of the Launchpad website to two of my peers for them to review and share their criticisms digitally. I asked them to look at each page separately and then at the whole thing to gather the feedback for the possible improvements for the website.

Participants

1st	Final Year Ideation Student
2nd	Final Year Ideation Student

Questions asked

1. Is the purpose of the website clear?
2. Is this a beneficial move towards freelancing?
3. Which feature would be most useful for graduates?
4. What can be improved?
5. Is there anything missing?

Responses

1st peer

1. Yes, they found it easy to identify what the website was trying to say.
2. They found that the provided support would be beneficial to freelancing.
3. They found the mentorship feature to be the best of the bunch.
4. They said that the learning page should have more descriptive courses and more courses in general on display.
5. A place where freelance job opportunities can be shown and interacted with

2nd peer

1. It is clear to see that it is intended to help support graduates
2. The access to communication between mentors is beneficial
3. The learning modules explain things that are not taught in universities
4. The mentor page can be more in-depth, including things like experience and what field they work in

Summary

From the feedback, we can see that the website's identity and purpose are clear, which is good because it also makes it easy to use. They both stated that the mentorship feature is good, which means that feedback on more in-depth descriptions is the top priority for improvement. Overall, the changes that need to be made are more learning content and freelance opportunities

Phase Reflection

Throughout the course of this phase, through the testing and feedback about Launchpad's website, the peers showed that the prototype could understand what Launchpad was about and provided apt feedback on how to improve it in the next stage, including a more detailed mentorship section and more courses on display to give a better experience for graduates who are using the site.

Reflecting, I found that this phase reinforced my understanding of the importance of testing a prototype. While the secondary research showed the most important areas where graduates were struggling when trying to move towards their own freelance careers, the evaluation and testing of the prototype reinforced that the idea supported it and was not straying in its own direction.

Refine

The purpose of this phase is to take the feedback provided from the Evaluation phase and iterate on the prototype to refine it, improving the functionality and usability.

Refined Prototype

Improved Mentor Page

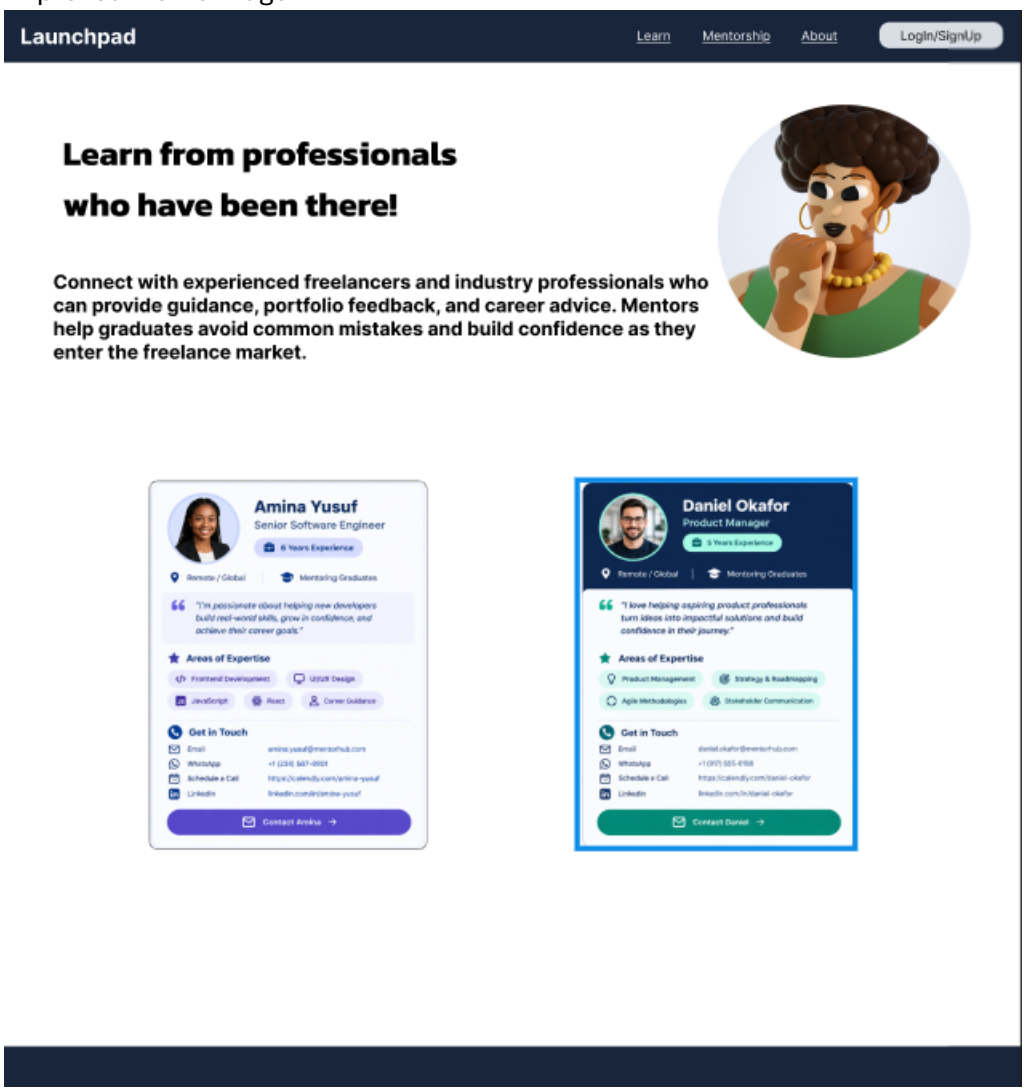


Figure 4 Improved mentor page

Improved Learning Page

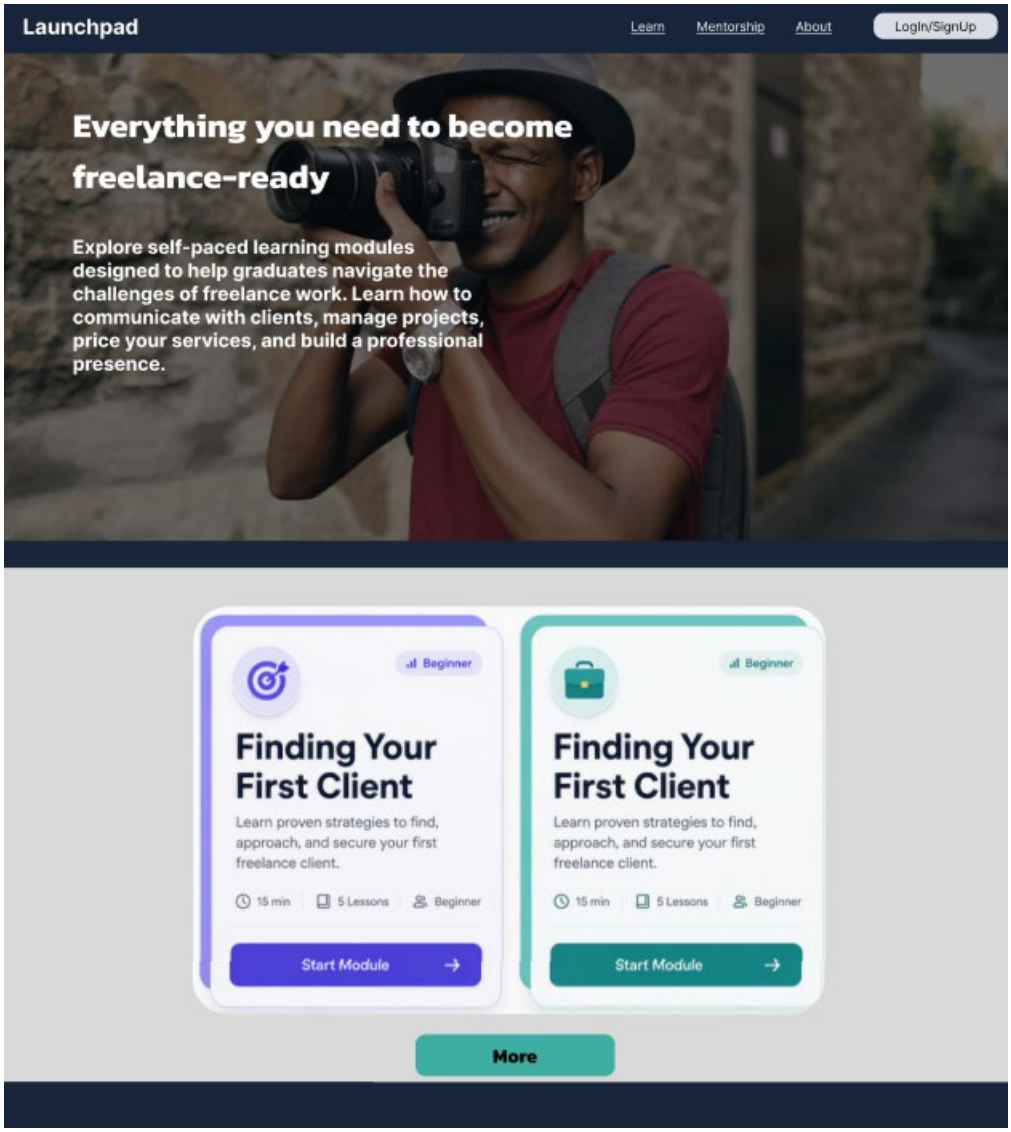


Figure 5 Improved Learn page

Proposed Project Timeline

Week 1	Finalise branding and design the system	1 week
Week 2	Develop the homepage and navigation	1 week
Week 3	Build the learning hub features	1 week
Week 4	Implement the mentorship section	1 week
Week 5	Build an opportunities platform	1 week
Week 6	Integrate a way to build and rate portfolios	1 week
Week 7	Test with beta users for bugs and glitches	1 week
Week 8	Preparations for the launch	1 week

Technical Requirements

For the front end, there would need to be a responsive website with mobile compatibility and interactive forms. For the back end, there would need to be User accounts and a database for mentors interested in participating in project listings and, eventually, progress tracking. The main things to include are the Learning modules and Mentor profiles, with opportunities for projects aimed at graduates.

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